



Eyebright

This tiny wildflower relies on nutrients stolen from the roots of nearby grasses.

Butter and eggs



The parasite steals nutrients from the roots of other plants to grow as tall as 14 in (35 cm).

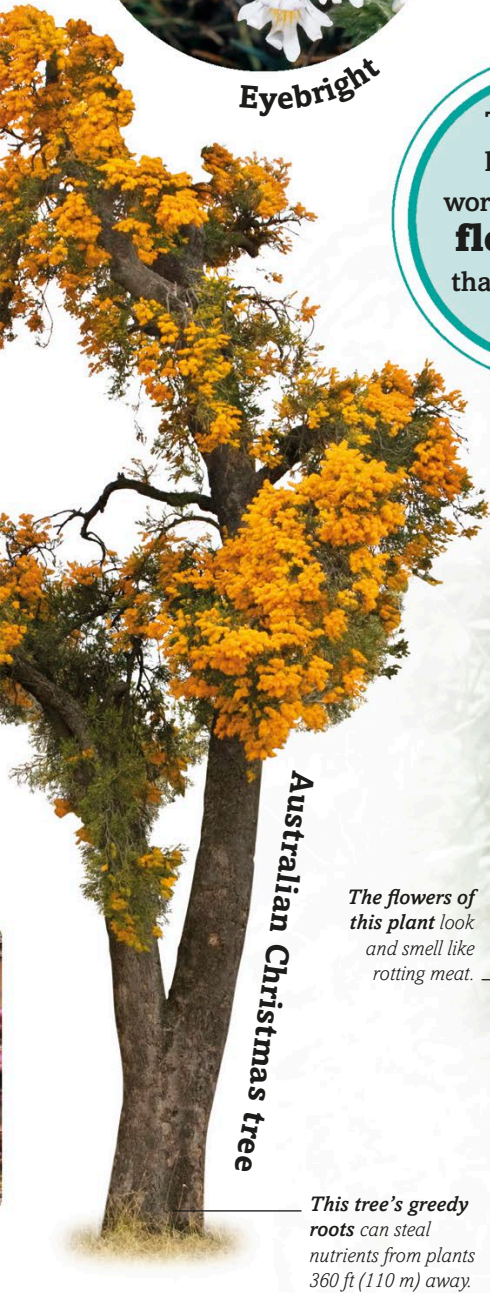
The corpse lily has the world's **largest flower**, more than 3 1/4 ft (1 m) across.

Corpse lily



The flowers of this plant look and smell like rotting meat.

Australian Christmas tree

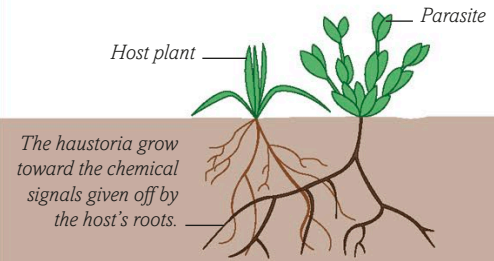


This tree's greedy roots can steal nutrients from plants 360 ft (110 m) away.



INVADING A HOST

All parasitic plants have modified roots called haustoria, which enter the roots or stems of host plants to steal food, water, and nutrients.



die if they cannot find a host to steal from. Others, including **eyebright** and **butter and eggs**, can survive without a host, although they tend to not grow as well. On the other hand, the second type, holoparasites (whole parasites), cannot make any food of their own and must find a host plant to survive.

Some holoparasites, such as **dodder**, grow above ground. Most, such as the **cactus mistletoe**, **Helosis**, **Thurber's stemsucker**, and the impressive **corpse lily**, live within their host plant, emerging only to flower. Parasitic plants do not generally kill their hosts but can weaken them.